BYTE-SIZE

YOUR WEEKLY DOSE OF IT INTELLIGENCE

GROWTH + REVENUE

0 to 200K in 8 Months

Turned a dormant email list into a $1.65M ARR revenue channel for a technical B2B audience of IT professionals and developers.

200K	60%	$1.65M	8
SUBSCRIBERS	OPEN RATE	PROJECTED ARR	MONTHS

THE PROBLEM

A 5-Million-Person Audience With Nothing to Read

Experts Exchange had tens of thousands of email contacts. Almost none of them were engaged.

The Email List Was Dead

Open rates hovered around 10%. Most sends were transactional or promotional with no consistent editorial identity. The list existed on paper, but it was not a channel anyone relied on for growth or revenue.

There was no reason for anyone to open these emails. No voice, no value, no consistency. Just noise in an inbox.

The Opportunity I Saw

The audience was 5M+ IT professionals and developers. People who follow industry news closely, care deeply about technical developments, and have zero tolerance for marketing fluff.

If the content actually respected their time and intelligence, the email channel could become far more valuable than anyone expected.

> *"I actually read this! I never read these kinds of emails. Very informative and entertaining. Just wanted to say thanks."*
>
> BYTESIZE READER

> *"I don't 'do' IT, but damn, I do enjoy your newsletter. I don't even know how you found your way into my Inbox. I really do connect with your type of humor."*
>
> BYTESIZE READER

> *"The witty take on big tech stories is the main reason I read this newsletter. It's concise, so not too much cognitive load."*
>
> BYTESIZE READER

MY ROLE

I Created ByteSize From Scratch

Concept, brand identity, editorial voice, production system, revenue model. All of it.

WHAT I BUILT

- Newsletter concept, name, and brand identity (ByteSize)
- Chip the mascot and full visual system
- Editorial voice and tone guidelines
- Weekly production workflow in ESP
- Landing page (go.experts-exchange.com/bytesize)
- Sponsorship packages and ad sales materials
- Pricing model for advertisers

WHAT I RAN

- Primary writer for the first several months
- Transitioned to executive editor as it scaled
- Story curation and content approval each week
- Visual asset production for every send
- Formatting QA and technical production
- Performance tracking and optimization
- Advertiser relationship management

THE EDITORIAL STRATEGY

Developers and IT professionals have a strong instinct for marketing fluff. The editorial tone leaned into humor, strong opinions, and practical relevance rather than corporate messaging.

Concise, high-signal updates on relevant technical developments. Written with a voice that acknowledged the intelligence and skepticism of the audience. Five-minute read, max.

THE REVENUE INSIGHT

A highly engaged niche audience is far more valuable than a large but disengaged one. At 60% open rates, advertisers were willing to pay a premium to reach this audience. Early sponsorship deals exceeded $10K per placement.

BRAND IDENTITY

Building a Newsletter People Actually Wanted to Open

The ByteSize Identity

I built the brand from the ground up: the name, the dot-matrix typography, the retro-computing visual language, and Chip, the 8-bit mascot. Every element was designed to signal "this is made by people who actually understand tech culture."

- Dot-matrix display font for the wordmark, nodding to early computing
- Chip the mascot: an 8-bit character that could express personality across formats
- Tagline: "Your Weekly Dose of IT Intelligence"
- Retro hardware imagery (keyboards, CRT monitors) grounding the brand in IT heritage
- Tone that balanced genuine expertise with irreverent humor

The brand needed to feel like it came from inside the IT community, not from a marketing department trying to reach it.

CONTENT ARCHITECTURE

Every Section Earns Its Place

Each issue follows a repeatable structure designed for scannability, value density, and personality.

📰

News Roundup

Must-know tech headlines and why they matter. Covering everything from French hackers demanding baguettes as ransom to Microsoft inventing a new state of matter.

🔧

Tool Time

Battle-tested tools that enhance productivity. Each recommendation includes a personality-driven description that makes enterprise software actually sound interesting.

💼

Job Opportunities

Career moves worth attention, carefully filtered to exclude ghost job postings. Real roles from real companies, not algorithmic spam.

🔄

Industry Moves

Weekly pulse check on mergers, acquisitions, product launches, and executive shuffles. The context behind the headlines.

CADENCE

Every Tuesday. Consistent enough to build habit, infrequent enough to stay welcome. Each issue is a five-minute read maximum.

VOICE

"We respectfully decline to use the phrase 'digital transformation journey.'" The tone treats readers as smart adults, not leads to be nurtured.

PRODUCTION

Story curation, writing/editing, visual asset creation, ESP formatting, QA, and performance tracking. All weekly, all operationalized.

GROWTH

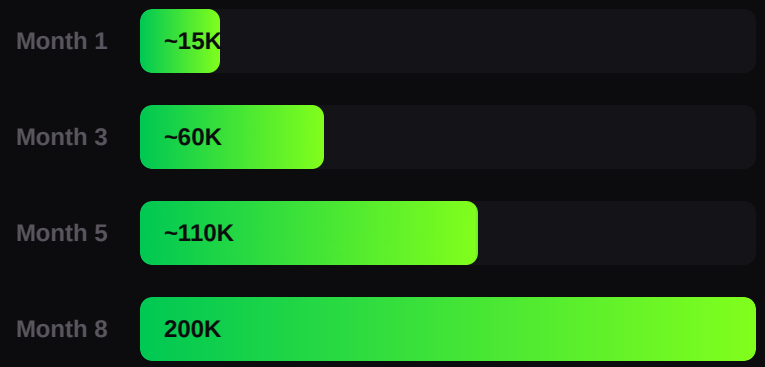
The Growth Curve

From a dead list to the company's most important channel in under a year.

~10%	60%	200K	6x
Starting Open Rate	Peak Open Rate	Subscribers at 8 Months	Open Rate Improvement

OPEN RATE TRANSFORMATION

SUBSCRIBER GROWTH (8 MONTHS)



What Drove the Growth

- Reactivation of dormant contacts through genuinely valuable content
- Organic referrals from readers who forwarded issues to colleagues
- Consistent quality that kept unsubscribe rates near zero
- Voice and tone that stood out from every other tech newsletter

The engagement level was not a spike. Open rates stabilized around 60% and stayed there. The audience was real, retained, and responsive.

REVENUE

From Content Channel to Revenue Engine

ByteSize became the company's top revenue channel within months of launch.

The Ad Model

I developed the sponsorship model from scratch: packages, pricing, sales materials, and the pitch to advertisers. The value proposition was simple: a highly engaged niche audience that other channels could not reach at this engagement level.

- Weekly cadence = ~52 sponsorship slots per year
- 60% open rate made every placement high-value
- 2-3% ad click-through rates (well above industry average)
- Early deals exceeding $10K per placement validated the pricing

$80K+
Initial Revenue Generated

$1.65M
Projected ARR at Scale

2-3%
Sponsor Ad CTR

$10K+
Early Placement Deals

READER RESPONSE

What Readers Say

Unsolicited feedback from real subscribers. These came in unprompted, week after week.

"I really enjoy the writing style. It's informative and witty and filled with asides and references that tickle my millennial brain."

READER

"The fact is you deliver excellent, compact content with wittiness. Short and sweet so keep it coming and thank you for your work."

READER

"Not sure if this reply will go to anyone, but I just had to say that your writers are FUNNNY! Thank you for brightening my day with interesting news in a way that made me laugh."

READER

"I read every week and frequently marvel at the cheeky references and asides with a 'I would never have thought of that but it's perfect!' kind of awe."

READER

"Tool time is absolutely great. The newsletter is absolutely great. Not much info, very condensed; a joy to read."

READER

"It's great to get some misc little news from this and that, I don't have time to look it all up myself. Not too elaborate. Love from Denmark."

READER

RESULTS

What It Delivered

200K
Subscribers in 8 Months

60%
Open Rate (Sustained)

$1.65M
Projected ARR

WHAT I BUILT

- Complete newsletter brand from concept to revenue
- Visual identity, mascot, and editorial voice
- Weekly production system and editorial workflow
- Sponsorship model, pricing, and sales materials
- Landing page and subscriber acquisition strategy
- Performance tracking and optimization loop

WHAT I LEARNED

- A niche audience with high engagement is worth more than a massive list with low engagement
- Voice and personality are competitive advantages, not nice-to-haves
- Treating readers as intelligent adults builds trust faster than any growth hack
- Revenue follows engagement, not the other way around
- Consistency in quality and cadence compounds over time

STILL RUNNING

ByteSize publishes every Tuesday and continues to grow. The brand, voice, and production system I built remain the foundation of the newsletter today.

THE BROADER IMPACT

ByteSize proved that Experts Exchange's audience, 5M+ IT professionals, could be activated through content that respected their intelligence. It became the template for how the company thought about audience engagement going forward.